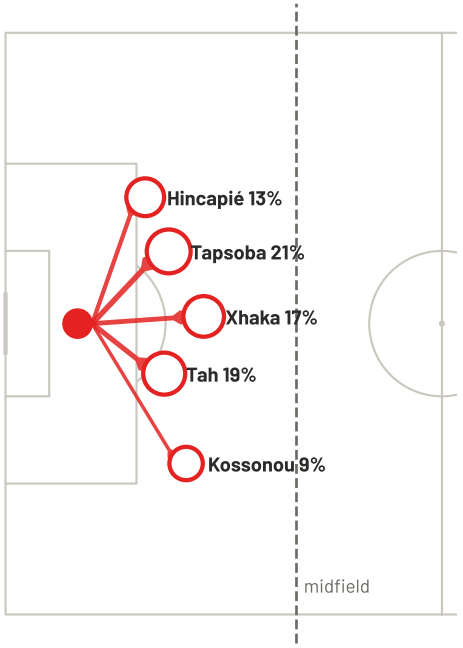
Getting out from the back

By Hammad · Bundesliga 2023/24, all 34 league matches · StatsBomb open data

THE QUESTION

How does Leverkusen get the ball from the goalkeeper into midfield?



PITCH DRAWING: WHO RECEIVES THE KEEPER'S SHORT PASSES

KEY FINDING

When Hrádecký goes short, 85% of possessions reach midfield. When he goes long, 47%. The short route runs through Xhaka dropping between the centre-backs.

WHAT

72% of goalkeeper possessions reached midfield before the opponent touched the ball (opponents: 52%). 39% reached the final third (17%).

HOW

Hrádecký went short 65% of the time (47%). Tapsoba (21%) and Tah (19%) split wide; Xhaka (17%) drops between them and took the ball into midfield most often (83 times, 41 by carrying it).

WHY IT WORKS

Xhaka dropping gives Leverkusen three passers in the first line, more than a front two can cover, and he can carry the ball forward himself. They broke into midfield evenly on the left (34%), centre (35%) and right (31%), so pressing one side doesn't shut them down.

NEXT: RECOMMENDATION FOR AN OPPONENT

Force Hrádecký long. Man-mark Xhaka when he drops and press the two centre-backs from the inside, so the short options are covered. Leverkusen's long goalkeeper passes reached midfield only 47% of the time.

EVIDENCE: NUMBERS

	Leverkusen	Opponents
Goalkeeper possessions	**765**	1043
Keeper went short (under 32 yards)	**65%**	47%
Reached midfield	**72%**	52%
Reached the final third	**39%**	17%
Ended in a shot	**7%**	3%
Goals	**7**	4

EVIDENCE: THREE MOMENTS (MATCH CLOCK)

52:17 Freiburg 2-3 Bayer Leverkusen: short pass, Xhaka takes it into midfield, Schick scores at 52:34 (17 s)

66:16 Bayer Leverkusen 3-0 FC Köln: short pass, Tapsoba takes it into midfield, Boniface scores at 66:31 (15 s)

59:58 Bayer Leverkusen 5-1 Darmstadt 98: short pass, Tah takes it into midfield, Boniface scores at 60:21 (23 s)

Goalkeeper possession = a possession in which the keeper passes. 'Reached' = by a completed pass or carry, before the opponent touched the ball.
Opponents = the other team in the same 34 matches.
Code and data: github.com/syedhammad07/football-analytics